



Strong Goals + Your Reach Job

AVC 248 • Design Self-Promotion • Week 4

“A vague goal can’t guide a single decision.”

THE PROBLEM

Most goals are too vague

Ask a designer their career goal and you usually get one foggy sentence. It sounds nice, but it can't actually steer anything.



Too broad

"I want a design job" fits a thousand roles and points at none of them.



No detail

No industry, no setting, no day-to-day. Nothing to plan around.



No direction

If it can't pick your next task, it can't guide your semester.

A goal you can't act on isn't really a goal yet.

What a strong goal includes

A strong goal is specific enough to plan around. It names all of these pieces:



Role



Industry



Setting



Location



Day-to-day



Timeline



Values



**Pay
range**

Name all eight, and your goal can finally do its job.

SEE THE DIFFERENCE

Weak vs. strong goal



Weak

"I want to get a graphic design job somewhere good after I graduate."

No role, industry, setting, pay, or timeline. Nothing to build on.



Strong

"Junior motion designer at a mid-size brand studio in Denver or remote, animating social and product spots day-to-day, hired within a year, on a team that values craft, paying \$58K to \$68K."

Every piece is named. You can plan around it.

Same person. One version you can act on.

Pick two real job postings

Turn your goal into something concrete by anchoring to real listings. You will pick two: one local you could actually walk into, and one reach that can be anywhere.



Job one: Local

A real studio, agency, or company near you. Career Services can build relationships with local employers, so a nearby target opens real doors.



Job two: Reach

A posting that excites you, just out of reach, anywhere. Slightly above your current level, something to grow into. It can be in any city or fully remote.

Two postings, chosen on purpose. One close to home, one to grow into.

WHERE TO LOOK

Creative jobs beyond Indeed

The best design roles often never hit the big generic boards. Search where creative employers actually post.

AIGA Design Jobs

The national design org's board.

Behance

Adobe's creative network and jobs.

Dribbble

Design community with a job board.

ArtStation

Strong for games and visual dev.

CreativeHeads

Games, film, and animation roles.

Authentic Jobs

Long-running design and dev board.

Working Not Working

Curated creative talent network.

Studio careers pages

Apply direct on a studio's own site.

Also find your local AIGA chapter. It is where nearby studios and designers gather.

TWO TARGETS

Everything aligns to them

Once your local and reach jobs are set, every assignment this semester points back at them. That is what keeps your work focused.



Your target jobs

sit at the center of it all.



Resume tailored to their exact requirements.



Interview prep built around their teams and roles.



Skill-building aimed at the gaps they reveal.

Two jobs, total alignment. No wasted effort, no guessing what to work on next.

Aim a little higher

A reach job stretches you on purpose. Even if you don't land that exact role, the work you do chasing it lifts everything.



It pulls you up

Building toward a stretch role grows skills a safe job never would.



It keeps you motivated

A job you actually want is worth the steady effort all term.



You're ready either way

Land it, or land the next tier down fully prepared. You win both.

Reach high. The climb is where the growth happens.



Your goals and jobs are the foundation.

“Everything else is built on top of this.”